Where You Are: Understanding Mom's Care Needs Is Step One of Nine

The nine steps of the Medicaid Planning Roadmap, with yours marked.

Right now it's all one blur: the hospital, the care, the cost, the paperwork. It doesn't all need sorting out at once. There's an order to it, and you're at the beginning.

This page shows the whole road, where you are on it, and who is involved after this step.

Phase 1 · Assess

Understand where you are today.

1 **Understand** Care Needs → Levels of Care & Costs → Care Plan
You finish with: Immediate Care Needs Assessment

You are here. This step is about getting clear on the care Mom needs now. Your part of it ends with what changed, where she needs help today, what you've been told and your open questions written down, ready to bring to her care team and to your Medicaid planner.

2 **Organize** Income & Assets → Ownership & Expenses → Financial File
You finish with: Financial Snapshot & Care Cost Analysis

3 **Assess** Care & Nonfinancial Eligibility → Income & Assets → Barriers & Readiness
You finish with: Medicaid Readiness Assessment

Phase 2 · Plan

Develop and implement your strategy.

4 **Plan** Barriers & Issues → Priorities & Professional Team → Written Plan
You finish with: Medicaid Action Plan

5 **Legal** Authority & Documents → Property, Trusts & Transfers → Attorney Review
You finish with: Legal Issues & Attorney Review Brief

6 **Financial** Costs & Runway → Asset Treatment & Tools → Strategy & Documentation
You finish with: Financial Strategy & Implementation Plan

Phase 3 · Secure

Secure benefits, protect assets, and maintain eligibility.

7 **Apply** Prepare → Submit → Manage
You finish with: Medicaid Application File

8 **Protect** What May Be Protected → What May Remain Exposed → What Needs Ongoing Attention
You finish with: Asset Protection Report

9 **Maintain** Ongoing Requirements → Changes & Renewals → Maintenance System
You finish with: Medicaid Maintenance Plan

What this step produces

The step as a whole is finished when your family knows what care Mom needs, where it can be provided, roughly what it will cost, and what decision comes next. Those answers come from the people who assess her and from the providers themselves.

Your part is the written picture that makes those conversations easier: what changed, what you've seen her do and not do, the papers and dates you've been given, and the questions still open. It is a family's notes, organized. It isn't an assessment.

Who you'll be talking with during this step

At the hospital, your point person for the discharge may be a dedicated discharge planner, a social worker, a nurse or another member of staff. [1]

If Mom goes to a skilled nursing facility, a team from different medical fields plans her care there, and she, the family or someone acting on her behalf can help plan it. [2]

What happens next

Inside this step, the picture of Mom's care needs leads on to levels of care and costs, and then to a care plan. When you work with your Medicaid planner, their part is to review your picture of what changed, her current care needs and the discharge or transition ahead, to help you line up your questions about levels of care, Medicare coverage and cost for the facility and the care team, and to add the care picture to your family's planning file.

After that comes the step called Organize, which gathers income, assets, ownership and expenses into one financial file. The care picture you build now is what the later steps start from.

Who is involved, by role

- You and your family: noticing, gathering, writing down, asking.
- Mom: her own account of how she is doing and what she wants.
- Her doctors, nurses and therapists: what care she needs, and what anything means medically.
- The discharge planner or social worker: the plan for leaving, and where care can be provided.
- The hospital or facility's business office: what is being billed, and to whom.
- Your Medicaid planner: reviews the picture with you, helps line up your questions, and keeps the planning file.
- In later steps, other professionals: an elder law attorney for legal advice and documents, licensed professionals for insurance and financial products, and an applications specialist for the application.

What this page doesn't promise

How long any step takes, who will be available, or how things turn out. It doesn't say whether Mom will qualify for any program. Families move through the steps at different speeds. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You know where this step sits and what comes after it. The care interview is how you finish your part of it: it walks you through Mom's situation area by area and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The nine steps are the Medicaid Planning Roadmap's own. The descriptions of the discharge point person and of care planning in a skilled nursing facility come from the sources below.

1. Family Caregiver Alliance, Hospital Discharge Planning: A Guide for Families and Caregivers
2. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Assessments & care plans in Skilled Nursing Facilities

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From the Medicaid Planning Roadmap · Richard Ladson, Certified Medicaid Planner. Draft for review, generated 2026-10-04.